Before the Distance: The Story of John & Erin

Before the Distance: The Story of John & Erin
- Seconds Into Thunder
  - Part 1: The Three-Minute Bell
  - Part 2: Table Four
- Before the Distance
  - Part 1: The Frayed Mask
  - Part 2: When the Steel Doors Close
- Sanctuary in the Storm
  - The Locked Perimeter
- Not Her
  - The Practiced Smile

Before the Distance: The Story of John & Erin

Seconds Into Thunder

Part 1: The Three-Minute Bell

Date: 2004-09-17 at 19:00 America/New_York

The dual-motor drive base of John’s power wheelchair hummed in a steady, low-frequency harmony with Erin’s chair beside him as they crested the final paved incline leading up from the Commonwealth Green to the Ironstone archway of Kincaid Hall.

Anyone who tried to navigate Commonwealth Polytechnic Institute in a manual chair learned the hard way within forty-eight hours of freshman orientation that Blacksburg was carved into the side of the Blue Ridge Mountains. Between the sweeping oval bowl of the Commonwealth Green, the steep Ironstone steps climbing toward Faraday Hall on the Engineering Quad, and the grades leading off campus toward Progress Street NE, torque and battery reserves were non-negotiable.

John eased his thumb off the rubberized joystick mounted on his right armrest, bringing his chair to a smooth, zero-radius halt just inside the warm atrium of Kincaid Student Center. Beside him, his fraternal twin sister Erin tapped her own joystick into neutral and reached up to adjust her round tortoiseshell glasses, her long wavy brown hair catching the warm amber glow of the hall sconces.

“Check your battery gauge,” Erin said, glancing over at his armrest console. “That climb up from Faraday Hall always eats an extra bar.”

“Four green LEDs out of five,” John replied, adjusting his own matching tortoiseshell frames and smoothing the hem of his maroon sweater. He looked down the second-floor corridor toward the open double doors of the lounge, where a hand-lettered poster taped to the Ironstone pillar read *FRIDAY NIGHT CAMPUS SPEED-DATING MIXER — 7:00 PM*. “Which means I physically have more than enough range to turn around, take the elevator back down, and roll the two blocks home to Progress Street.”

“Not a chance,” Erin grinned, nudging the rubber bumper of her footplate lightly against the side of his caster wheel. “You promised me one hour out of the lab. Twenty tables, three minutes per round. If it’s a disaster, we hit The Foundry for late-night waffle fries and call it field research.”

They rolled side by side into the Second-Floor Lounge. The student activities volunteers had arranged twenty small circular tables in a wide ring around the room, leaving generous four-foot lanes between them so both John and Erin could maneuver their power chairs into the odd-numbered anchor spots without scraping a single chair leg. Erin claimed Table 1 near the windows overlooking Commonwealth Mall, while John parked at Table 4, flipping the standard wooden chair aside and locking his drive wheels into position flush against the tabletop.

At the front of the room, a sophomore wearing a CPI Student Activities polo stood behind a rolling media cart equipped with a dual-deck AudioStar CD system and two amplified PA speakers.

“Alright, everyone, welcome!” the organizer called out into a handheld microphone, tapping the grille twice. “Instead of using an obnoxious kitchen timer or a whistle to signal the end of each rotation, we’re keeping things civilized tonight. Every round is timed to Track 3 on the new **Progress Street** CD by CPI’s own **The Stardust Engine**—**‘Seconds Into Forever’**. It’s an eighty-five-BPM power ballad, and it runs exactly three minutes and zero seconds. When the synth pad fades out at the end of the song, you thank your partner and rotate one table to the left!”

He pressed play on the first round. Warm, sparkling synthesizer pads and clean electric guitar arpeggios floated out of the speakers:

The clock is ticking on the classroom wall But time stands still here in the hall I saw your face and the world went blurred The sweetest song that I ever heard No need to run and no need to hide I’m pulling up a chair right by your side

John let his shoulders drop an inch. The first three rotations were pleasant, polite, and entirely predictable—three minutes with a civil engineering major from Joule Hall debating bridge trusses, three minutes with an architecture student sketching on

her napkin, and three minutes with a quiet girl from Roanoke who spent two of the minutes asking about the top speed of his power chair on the Commonwealth Green paths.

Across the room at Table 1, Erin caught his eye as the third round's sustained synth chord faded out. She flashed him a quick thumbs-up from her armrest.

See? her expression said. *Harmless.*

"Alright, folks, rotate to Round Four!" the organizer announced over the PA.

Part 2: Table Four

Date: 2004-09-17 at 19:20 America/New_York

A woman in a fitted black leather jacket stepped into the open space opposite Table 4 and pulled out the wooden chair across from John's power wheelchair.

Unlike the previous three students, who had glanced nervously at their name tags or at the empty floor space where his chair was parked, she didn't look down at his drive wheels or his joystick controller. She rested her elbows on the small round table, leaned forward into his immediate field of view, and locked her dark eyes directly onto his behind his tortoiseshell glasses.

"I've been waiting three tables to get to this side of the room," she said, her voice low, smooth, and unhurried. "I'm Valerie."

"John," he said, offering a polite smile. "Wait—weren't you over by Table 9 a minute ago? That's five tables back."

"I traded numbers with two girls in line so I wouldn't have to wait," Valerie replied without missing a beat, flashing a sharp, magnetic smile that made John's pulse jump. "Everyone else in this room is making small talk about syllabus week. You've been actually listening to every person who sat down in front of you. You're rare, John."

Up at the front media cart, the student organizer was juggling a stack of sign-in clipboards with one hand while reaching blindly for the |<< restart button on the AudioStar CD player with the other. In his rush, his thumb missed the back button by half an inch and jammed down hard on >>| instead—skipping right past Track 3 and landing on Track 4, **"Thunder in the Rain"**.

For ten seconds, a lush, cinematic analog brass-synth swell filled the lounge. Half the room assumed it was an extended intro to the ballad.

Then—*CRASH.*

An explosive acoustic drum fill and a blistering C-minor synthesizer stab tore through the PA speakers at 150 beats per minute, followed by a roaring, high-gain stadium guitar riff that rattled the water pitchers on the tables:

The clock on the wall is a guillotine blade Cutting down the promises we never made I see you standing there across the crowded floor Like a lighthouse burning on a midnight shore!

“Whoa, wrong track!” the organizer yelped, dropping his clipboards as papers scattered across the carpet. He fumbled with the volume knob, accidentally turning the master fader up before the remote slipped under the cart.

Across the room, students laughed and shouted over the sudden wall of stadium rock, waiting for him to fix the deck.

At Table 4, Valerie didn’t flinch or look toward the speakers. Instead, she reached across the narrow tabletop and placed her hand directly over John’s wrist where it rested near his joystick controller. Her palm was warm, her grip surprisingly firm.

Don’t tell me to wait, don’t tell me to stop I’m a runaway train and I’m blowing the top The neon signs are flashing “Danger” in red But I’d rather be living than safe and dead Hold on tight, baby, don’t let go We’re dancing on the edge of the volcano!

“Leave it!” Valerie laughed over the roaring chorus, her eyes shining as she leaned closer to John. “Everyone else gets a polite little three-minute lullaby. You and I get the storm. Tell me that isn’t a sign.”

John’s heart hammered against his ribs in time with the 150-BPM kick drum. Used to being treated either as an academic study partner or as a Fragile Accommodation Request by strangers on campus, the sheer, undivided intensity of her focus felt intoxicating.

He smiled back into the spotlight of her attention.

“Yeah,” John said over the thunder of the guitars. “Maybe it is.”

Before the Distance

Part 1: The Frayed Mask

Date: 2004-11-18 at 17:15 America/New_York

Cold November rain slanted sideways across Commonwealth Mall, drumming against a wall of umbrellas and pooling in dark, diesel-streaked puddles along the granite curb beneath the vaulted Ironstone arch of The Keystone Bridge.

Along Commonwealth Mall, catching a bus at five o’clock on a weekday evening was an absolute logistical nightmare. Every single Blue Ridge Transit route staged bumper-to-bumper along the open curb between Kincaid Hall and Pendleton Library, their forty- and sixty-foot diesel engines idling in a deafening, exhaust-choked line while delivery vans, soaked pedestrians, and bicycles fought for every inch of wet asphalt.

Erin sat in her power wheelchair on the sidewalk just inside the dry stone shadow of The Keystone Bridge’s northern arch, her maroon CPI windbreaker zipped to her chin and her hands tucked into fleece-lined gloves. The twins’ accessible ground-floor apartment on Progress Street NE was only two blocks away—a five-minute roll down the sidewalk—and John had promised to meet her here after his afternoon lab so they could head home together. Yet every thirty seconds, Erin’s eyes flicked

from the chaotic wall of glowing amber LED bus headboards lining the Commonwealth Mall curb down the long, wet concrete incline leading up from Faraday Hall and the Commonwealth Green.

It had been sixty-two days since the speed-dating mixer in Kincaid Hall.

In the first two weeks after that Friday night, Valerie had seemed like a whirlwind romance. She had walked beside John's power chair to every class at Faraday Hall, brought him coffee at Pendleton Library, and praised Erin as "the coolest twin sister on campus."

Then, week three had arrived, and the perimeter had begun closing like a vise.

First came the canceled Friday dinners on Progress Street NE—always explained away by a sudden "migraine" or an "emergency" that required John to take the Blue Ridge Transit bus south to Valerie's off-campus duplex in Christiansburg. Next came the phone calls where Valerie's voice was audible in the background, coaching John on what to say, followed by nights when John's cell phone went straight to voicemail for thirty-six hours at a stretch. When Erin had finally bumped into them outside the Kincaid Hall bookstore the previous week, Valerie had answered every single question directed at John, smiling coldly while resting both hands on the rear push-handles of John's power wheelchair as if she owned the chassis.

Erin's jaw tightened as two figures finally appeared through the mist at the bottom of the rain-slicked pedestrian walk from the Commonwealth Green.

John's power wheelchair was climbing the grade toward The Keystone Bridge at half its normal speed. Even from forty feet away, Erin could see why: Valerie was walking right beside his left wheel, one hand clamped tightly around the upright frame of his backrest while the other held a single black umbrella angled entirely over her own head, leaving cold rainwater to drip steadily off the rims of John's tortoiseshell glasses.

As they rolled beneath the vaulted Ironstone arch of The Keystone Bridge beside the roaring curbside line of buses, Erin felt a cold knot twist in her stomach. Through the open window of the Kincaid Hall student lounge above them, the mid-tempo synth heartbeat and dramatic drums of **"Before the Distance"** drifted out into the November mist:

> *"I saw the shadow falling across your face A quiet surrender in a crowded place You wore a mask, but the edges were frayed Lost in the rules of a game that we played I should have reached out, I should have stood tall But I let the silence echo down the hall…"*

John looked hollowed out. Dark, bruised shadows hung beneath his eyes. His shoulders were hunched inward over his armrests, his gaze fixed on the wet concrete three feet ahead of his front casters—a quiet surrender in a crowded place. He wore a polite, practiced smile as he looked up at Erin, but the edges of the mask were completely frayed.

"Hey, Er," John said quietly, his voice barely audible over the hiss of air brakes along the Commonwealth Mall curb.

“You’re soaking wet, John,” Erin said, driving her chair forward half a length so she was directly facing her brother. She pulled a dry microfiber cloth from her side pouch and held it out for his glasses. “Come on—home is two blocks away. Let’s get you out of the rain and back to Progress Street so we can warm up and go over the thermodynamics packet.”

Before John could reach for the cloth, Valerie stepped half a pace forward, positioning her hip right beside John’s armrest controller.

“We have plans, Erin,” Valerie said, her tone syrupy and sharp all at once. She took the cloth out of Erin’s hand and wiped the rain off John’s frames herself, as though John’s own arms didn’t work. “And honestly, John is completely burned out from carrying your shared study load this semester. He’s not going back to Progress Street with you tonight. We only stopped by Commonwealth Mall so he could drop off your textbook before he gets on the bus with me for the weekend.”

Erin didn’t look at Valerie. She kept her eyes locked straight on her twin brother’s face.

When Valerie mentioned getting on the bus to go to her place for the weekend, John’s right hand—resting near his joystick—flinched almost imperceptibly, his knuckles turning white against the black foam pad. He didn’t argue. He didn’t correct her. He just looked down at his lap, reaching into his backpack with trembling fingers to pull out the heavy hardcover textbook.

In twenty years of sharing a life, John had never once flinched at the thought of going home.

He’s trapped, Erin realized, the cold math locking into place in her chest. *Home is two blocks away, and she’s forcing him onto that bus to isolate him for the entire weekend.*

Part 2: When the Steel Doors Close

Date: 2004-11-18 at 17:30 America/New_York

At the curb directly beside them, a sixty-foot articulated Blue Ridge Transit coach hissed to a stop in the bumper-to-bumper lineup along Commonwealth Mall. Its amber overhead LED sign glowed through the sheets of rain—`1 FALLING BRANCH` —as the front pneumatic suspension kneeled toward the granite curb, the dual-leaf front boarding doors folded open, and the yellow-bordered aluminum ADA wheelchair ramp unfolded onto the wet sidewalk.

“That’s our bus, John,” Valerie said briskly, tapping the back of John’s shoulder as she stepped toward the foot of the front-door ramp. “Put your chair in gear and roll on up. Erin has her textbook—she can walk the two blocks back to Progress Street on her own.”

For three seconds, Erin sat frozen under the stone arch of The Keystone Bridge, the heavy textbook resting in her lap. Every polite social rule she had been raised with told her to nod, stay out of a couple’s argument in public, and roll the two blocks back to Progress Street NE alone.

Then John looked back at her as Valerie nudged his backrest toward the open front door of the bus.

His glasses were fogged at the edges, his shoulders hunched against the freezing Blacksburg rain, his right hand limp and motionless beside his controller. In his eyes was a silent, drowning plea—a man about to be swallowed by the distance the second those steel bus doors closed behind him:

> *"When the steel doors close and the platform clears You can hear the truth grinding in the gears Heed the warning hiding in his eyes Before the distance leaves your soul behind Trust the silence when he calls your name 'Cause once it's gone, nothing stays the same…"*

Not tonight, Erin thought. *Logic is a cage when the danger is real—you can't code the panic, you can't fake what you feel. Whatever it costs me, I'm taking him back.*

Before John's front casters could touch the bottom lip of the aluminum bus ramp, Erin pushed her joystick forward. Her dual electric motors engaged with a deep, authoritative hum. She drove straight out from beneath the bridge arch across the rain-slicked sidewalk of Commonwealth Mall, cutting across the concrete at a sharp angle and locking her brakes directly between John's footrests and the deployed front ramp of the bus.

Cold rain pelted her maroon CPI jacket and speckled the lenses of her glasses as she reached across the narrow gap between their armrests, covering John's cold, trembling right hand with her warm palm.

"Don't get on that bus, John," Erin said, her voice ringing clear and steady over the rumble of the idling diesel engine. "Come home with me instead. Progress Street is two blocks away."

Valerie's practiced, patient smile vanished. "Erin, excuse me—you are literally blocking the bus ramp. John and I are going to my place for the weekend, and the driver is waiting. Move your chair."

"I'm not talking to you," Erin said without glancing in Valerie's direction. She kept her eyes locked entirely on her twin brother's face, her fingers tightening protectively over his wrist on the armrest. "John, look at me. You don't want to get on this bus. I can see it in your eyes. Home is two blocks down the sidewalk. Turn your chair around and come home with me."

"Erin, I—" John's voice cracked, his chest rising and falling rapidly as he looked from the open doorway of the bus to his sister's rain-streaked face. "Valerie already made plans for the weekend, and if I don't get on the bus—"

"John, get on the bus right now!" Valerie snapped, her voice dropping half an octave as the honeyed veneer shattered in front of the whole queue of wet undergrads waiting along Commonwealth Mall. She clamped her manicured fingers tightly onto John's wet sleeve, trying to pull his arm toward the joystick to steer him around Erin's frame. "I am not standing out here in the rain having a scene with your sister! Drive up the ramp, now!"

"Take your hand off his sleeve," Erin said.

She didn’t shout. She didn’t have to. There was an immovable, bedrock certainty in her voice—the same quiet steel that had carried both of them through nineteen years of hospital corridors, physical therapy gyms, and steep mountain grades.

“John,” Erin said softly, squeezing his hand at the foot of the ramp. “Remember the fourth-grade hill behind the middle school when my battery cable snapped in the sleet? You hooked your tow strap to my frame and burned out half your motor pulling both of us to the top. You don’t owe anyone your disappearance. Don’t let those doors close on you. Come home with me.”

John looked down at Erin’s hand clasped over his across their armrests. Then he looked at Valerie’s white-knuckled grip twisting his jacket sleeve toward the bus ramp—and at the flash of cold, undisguised fury in Valerie’s eyes now that the polite mask had slipped away.

Something inside John’s chest unlocked.

“Last call for Route 1!” the bus operator called out from the driver’s seat, his hand hovering over the ramp toggle switch. “Are you folks boarding or staying?”

“He’s staying,” Erin said.

“I’m staying,” John echoed, his voice steadying for the first time in weeks.

He pulled his arm free from Valerie’s grasp, gripped his joystick, and pulled it straight back. His electric motors hummed in unison with Erin’s as he reversed his power wheelchair three feet away from the aluminum ramp, pivoting on the wet concrete until his wheels were aligned side-by-side with his twin sister’s on the Commonwealth Mall sidewalk.

At the curb, the hydraulic pump whined. The yellow-bordered aluminum ramp folded upward into the front stepwell with a heavy metallic clank, and the dual-leaf steel doors hissed shut—sealing the bus closed while John and Erin remained together on the sidewalk.

Sanctuary in the Storm

The Locked Perimeter

Date: 2004-11-18 at 17:35 America/New_York

As the first articulated coach pulled away from the granite curb in a cloud of diesel spray, a second Blue Ridge Transit bus immediately rolled forward to take its place along the Commonwealth Mall sidewalk, its air brakes sighing as its front boarding doors hissed open.

Valerie hadn’t gotten on the first bus. Instead, she stepped across the wet concrete directly into the path of the twins’ power wheelchairs, her black umbrella trembling in her fist as freezing November rain lashed sideways beneath the arch of The Keystone Bridge.

“John, stop being ridiculous and get on the bus right now,” Valerie demanded, pointing toward the open front door of the second coach idling at the curb. Every trace of the warm, magnetic woman from Table 4 was gone, replaced by a brittle, commanding fury. “The driver just opened the ramp. If you let your sister drag you down the street like a child instead of getting on this bus with me right now, we are done. Do you hear me? Get on the bus!”

A conditioned reflex twitched in John’s shoulders—two months of trained muscle memory telling him to apologize, to appease her, to roll up that ramp just to stop the storm in her voice.

Beside him on the sidewalk, Erin didn’t yield an inch.

She eased her thumb forward on her joystick, advancing her power wheelchair half a length and angling her heavy steel frame at forty-five degrees between Valerie and John’s left drive wheel—establishing a physical, locked perimeter right on the Commonwealth Mall sidewalk.

“He’s not getting on the bus, Valerie,” Erin said, her voice steady and immovable over the drumming rain. “Home is two blocks from here. John is coming home.”

“Stay out of this, Erin!” Valerie snapped, trying to sidestep Erin’s front casters to reach for John’s backrest handle again. “John, tell her! Get on the bus!”

Erin matched Valerie’s step with a zero-latency pivot of her drive wheels, keeping her chair’s frame locked squarely across Valerie’s path so she couldn’t get within arm’s reach of John’s controls. Then Erin looked over her shoulder at her brother and held out her left hand.

“John,” Erin said gently, the storm howling down the avenue around them while her voice remained an island of absolute calm. “Take my hand. Two blocks down the sidewalk, and we’re home.”

John looked at Valerie standing beside the idling bus—demanding his obedience as the price of her affection—and then he looked at his fraternal twin sister, soaking wet in the November rain, shielding his chair with her own body and chassis.

For the first time in two months, the fog inside John’s head cleared completely.

“Go catch your bus, Valerie,” John said quietly.

He reached across the gap between their armrests and clasped Erin’s gloved hand firmly in his. With his right thumb, he pushed his joystick forward.

Together, wheel to wheel on the wide brick-and-concrete sidewalk, John and Erin rolled out from beneath The Keystone Bridge, turning their backs on the Commonwealth Mall bus line and heading northeast toward Progress Street NE.

Behind them, Valerie’s voice echoed sharply across the wet pavement for a few yards before the roar of the departing buses and the driving rain swallowed it whole. Thirty seconds later, as the twins crossed the corner onto the tree-lined sidewalk of Progress Street NE—just two blocks from Commonwealth Mall—John’s flip phone began vibrating frantically inside his jacket pocket.

Bzzzt. Bzzzt. Bzzzt.

Every ten yards along the sidewalk, another text message arrived—first furious ultimatums, then wounded accusations, then sudden demands that he turn around and meet her at the next stop.

As they rolled up to the concrete front porch ramp of their ground-floor apartment on Progress Street NE, Erin kept her chair positioned on the outside edge of the sidewalk—maintaining her locked perimeter between her brother and the street until John's front tires cleared the porch threshold.

Under the dry shelter of the porch awning, Erin reached into John's side pocket, pulled out the buzzing flip phone, and held down the red power key until the little blue LCD screen went dark.

"Out of range," Erin said softly, tucking the silent phone into her pouch and unlocking the front door.

Inside, the apartment was warm and quiet, smelling of cinnamon, dry wool, and safe harbor. On the bookshelf stereo by the window, the dramatic grand piano and shimmering synthesizer pads of **"Sanctuary in the Storm"** played softly in the warm room:

> *"You are my sanctuary in the storm A fire here to keep me safe and warm Wh en the thunder rolls and the cold winds blow I'll never let you go We are a sanctuary in the storm…"*

As the heavy deadbolt clicked shut behind them, sealing out the November gale, John let out a long, shuddering breath and rested his forehead against his sister's shoulder.

"You stood right in front of the ramp for me," John whispered, his voice thick as his eyes stung behind his wet glasses. "When she kept insisting I get on that bus… you locked the whole sidewalk down."

Erin wrapped her arms around his shoulders, her glasses bumping lightly against his temple, and held on tight.

"Always, John," Erin whispered back. "Home was only two blocks away. And the storm stays outside."

Not Her

The Practiced Smile

Date: 2005-04-08 at 21:30 America/New_York

Spring arrived late on the plateau, trading November's sleet for warm April rain that smelled of wet Ironstone and blooming dogwoods along Commonwealth Mall.

It was nine-thirty on a Friday night outside the Kincaid Hall Auditorium, where the spring undergraduate research symposium had just let out. John guided his power wheelchair down the interior accessibility ramp toward the east colonnade, a rolled-

up poster tube tucked beside his armrest and two cups of hot cider balanced in his cupholder tray. Erin had gone ahead five minutes earlier to grab her rain poncho from the coat check near the side exit.

As John rounded the Ironstone pillar at the end of the breezeway, the low murmur of the departing crowd faded behind the heavy glass doors—and a voice echoed from the recessed concrete alcove beside the service elevator.

“Come on, Erin, you don’t need to wait around for your brother every Friday night,” a smooth, practiced baritone was saying. “Honestly, it’s a little unfair how much he leans on you. A girl as brilliant as you shouldn’t have to play caretaker just because you share a birthday. Let me drive you home—we’ll load your chair in the back of my SUV, grab a drink downtown, and you can finally have a night to yourself.”

John stopped his chair in the shadow of the archway. Every nerve in his body went ice-cold, and then white-hot.

He knew that cadence. He knew the exact melody of **“Not Her”**—that easy charm, that practiced smile, the subtle poison designed to make love look like a burden and family look like a cage:

> *“I see you move, I see your style That easy charm, that practiced smile You think you’re clever, think you’re slick You’ve got your whole routine down to a trick You see a quiet, gentle soul Another prize to make you whole But I’ve seen that look in someone’s eyes before And I won’t let you walk through that door…”*

In the recessed alcove by the elevator, Erin sat in her power wheelchair with her back flush against the Ironstone wall. Standing directly in front of her footrests was Garrett Sterling, a senior from the business school wearing a tailored charcoal coat. He had planted one polished leather boot on the base of the concrete ramp and rested his left hand on the top edge of the wall beside Erin’s shoulder, effectively boxing her chair into the narrow corner so she couldn’t pivot without clipping his shins.

“I told you, Garrett, I’m heading home with John,” Erin said. Her voice was steady, but John knew his sister better than anyone alive—he saw the way her right thumb was tensed against her joystick, searching for a three-inch clearance that wasn’t there. “Please step back from my footrests so I can turn around.”

“I’m just saying, you let him keep you on a short leash,” Garrett said, leaning in another inch with a slow, patronizing grin that expected compliance. “Just five minutes, Erin. Tell me why you’re always running away when someone tries to—”

“She said step back.”

John’s voice cut across the Ironstone colonnade like a steel cable snapping under tension.

He didn’t keep his chair in indoor low-speed mode. He thumbed his controller to its highest outdoor climbing gear and drove straight up the concrete incline into the alcove. The heavy front anti-tip rollers and steel footplate of his power wheelchair surged into the narrow gap between Garrett and Erin’s chair, forcing Garrett to stumble backward half a pace or lose his ankles to two hundred and fifty pounds of rolling steel and battery torque.

John locked his brakes at a forty-five-degree angle directly in front of his twin sister, placing the full frame of his chair as a physical barricade between Garrett and Erin.

Garrett blinked, the slick smile vanishing into a flush of startled irritation. “Hey—watch where you’re driving that thing, man. Erin and I were just having a private conversation.”

“No, you weren’t,” John said. He didn’t raise his voice, and he didn’t look away. Behind the lenses of his glasses, his eyes were steady and surgical. “You were blocking her turning radius with your boot, putting your hand over her exit path, and trying to sell her the oldest lie in the book—that the people who protect her are the ones holding her back.”

Garrett let out a sharp, defensive laugh, glancing toward the empty hallway. “You’re paranoid, man. I was just offering your sister a ride home.”

“I know exactly what you were offering,” John said:

> *“I know your game, I know your kind The little traps you leave behind You think she’s weak, a fragile prey But you’re not taking her away I’ve walked through fire, I’ve paid the cost And I won’t let another light be lost Not her. Not today.”*

“I’ve heard that script word for word,” John continued, his voice cold iron. “I know how it starts, I know how the flattery works, and I know what happens the moment the door closes. You can try that routine in a mirror, Garrett, or you can walk out of this building right now. Because you will never get within ten feet of my sister again. Not tonight. Not ever. Not her.”

For three seconds, the only sound in the east colonnade was the low, twin hum of two power wheelchair converters idling in unison. Behind John’s shoulder, Erin maneuvered her chair out of the corner until her wheel aligned parallel with his—a solid, two-wide phalanx of steel and shared resolve.

Garrett looked at John’s unblinking stare, then at Erin’s cold, steady gaze beside him. Whatever easy target he had imagined existed in this alcove was gone. Mutters of face-saving bravado died in his throat; he adjusted the lapels of his coat, turned on his heel, and walked briskly out the side exit into the rain.

The heavy glass door swung shut behind him.

For a long moment, neither twin spoke. Then Erin exhaled, reached across the gap between their armrests, and tapped the back of John’s knuckles with her own.

“You nearly took his Italian leather toes off,” Erin said, the corner of her mouth curving upward.

“He was standing in the ADA turning lane,” John replied, the tension in his jaw finally softening as he handed her one of the warm paper cups of apple cider from his tray. “Come on, Erin. Home’s only two blocks down the sidewalk.”

Side by side, their electric motors humming in matched harmony, John and Erin rolled out under the Ironstone arches of the Kincaid colonnade and down the wet sidewalk from Commonwealth Mall to Progress Street NE—together, and all the way home.

> **Companion Perspectives Across the Universe: * The Stardust Engine (`books.raggiesoft.com/stardust-engine` & `stardust.raggiesoft.com`)**: Read how **Ryan and Cassidy O'Connell** wrote and recorded the five-song *John & Erin* story on Progress Street in **The Stardust Engine — Book 4, Chapter 2: *Writing Before the Distance on Progress Street (2004)***, and explore the full 5-song soundtrack playlist at **`music.raggiesoft.com/playlists/john-and-erin`**. * **The Sound of Distant Thunder (`books.raggiesoft.com/michael`)**: Read how **Jessica Miller** listens to *"Before the Distance"* on her commuter train from Kent Station to Seattle King Street Station in November 2006 and realizes she and her brother **Michael** are living out the exact story of John and Erin in **The Sound of Distant Thunder (`books/michael`)**.